WHEN BEING AN ALLY TURNS INTO BEING AN

APPROPRIATOR

[SETTLER CONDUCT AND SELF CHECK]

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Settler Conduct and Self Check

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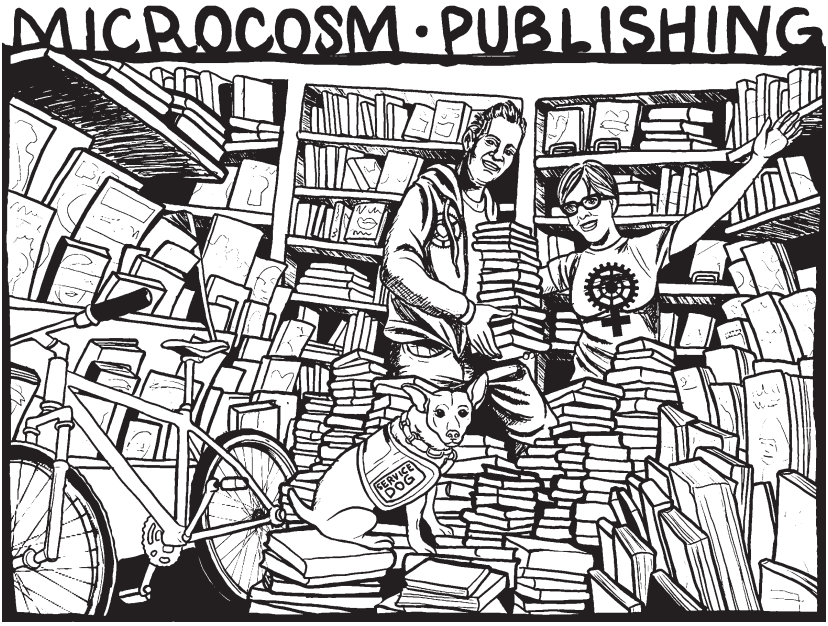

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THIS IS IN RESPONSE TO A FEW INQUIRIES WE HAVE GOTTEN AS OF LATE ABOUT NOT OVERSTEPPING BOUNDARIES WHEN WORKING WITH INDIGENOUS, HOW MUCH HELP IS TOO MUCH HELP AND WHEN TO DRAW THE LINE, BETWEEN HELPING AND APPROPRIATING AND PROMOTING ONE'S OWN NEED FOR GRATIFICATION BY DOING SOMETHING WITHIN THE STRUGGLE THAT IS MEANINGFUL.

Networking and sharing is essential between settlers, settlers of color and indigenous, if we do not network and work together than we are making this battle doubly hard on ourselves, all to often though, privilege and pride come into play and with that comes dangerous consequences.

This is not to say that settlers and settler people of color have no place in our spaces or movements it means that no matter how eager you are to learn and to help always vigilantly watch yourself that you are not overwhelming or undermining the very people you want to work along side with.

There is nothing so offensive, or off-putting as seeing non indigenous at the forefront of our issues in our struggles blow horning around, giving expert analysis about what we are up to in our own actions, while an indigenous contingent is there in the background looking stoic and nodding.

We are not yes people, we are not tokens, and no matter how much a settler or SPOC grasps of the situation they will never have our world view or our passion. That is not to say they have no validity, the point being if you are taking on a support role as part of indigenous resistance and you are not indigenous please respect your support role and do not over step the boundaries and the honour of being involved and allowed into the movement.

Before I go on, I also want to pre acknowledge the facts that the genocide of our indigenous here in the so called "new world", the slave trade and genocide of the African people now known as "African American" have a common goal and and our liberation from the "amerikkkan dream" has been entwined since contact, we have always seen a kindred spirit in each other and often times worked together and intermarried. This also is the same of any people that were brought here as slaves, and treated to murder for the "privilege" - the Chinese, and the Japanese, et al.

I find that it is wearying to mention or say anything anymore because there is always excuses, and defensive passive aggression that follows as well as the defensive protecting of these favoured non indigenous people by their indigenous sponsor.

The free pass taking and the free pass giving is rampant and is something we haven't been exempt from which is why we are working on talking about this neo-colonial behaviour in ourselves too, I talk about these hard subjects and put it out there because it is a learning process, I want to foster a healthy dialogue that creates spaces where we can openly and with respect educate others who may not be aware they are doing this or that it is happening around them to see and than to learn from it and move on.

We all make mistakes and we all come through the other end of these types of interactions with more experience and lessons to share. If you already are feeling defensive or angry than maybe that means this is work that has to be done by you in your interactions as settler, settler of color, or indigenous person.

In fact it was definitely my defensive anger and reactions that drove me to explore these feelings more in depth and to challenge myself to stop letting people have free passes on my name, and time because ultimately I am the one who has to deal with the emotional fall out if things go sideways, possibly losing close friends or allies because of this.

I am also the one being stifled because I am stuck in a position that is all too familiar with many indigenous organizers, activists, land defenders, indigianarchists, etcetera. The position of being the one who calls out these types of situations, the negative ndn, or the angry one, the person who cant control their feelings or is being divisive because it raises the need to make time for this

CHITAAPI - CATFACE MOUNTAIN, AHOUSAT

discussion and "THERE IS MORE IMPORTANT THINGS HAPPENING HERE SACHEEN CANT WE JUST TALK ABOUT THIS LATER?" Well later never usually comes and nothing is more important than nipping this stuff in the bud before it can take root.

Not to mention there is always the anxiety and the self doubt that even though you know these are valid real issues that need being dealt with it can mean being seen as always someone who cant just let things go or just take it easy.

Sometimes this loop of thinking and of not wanting any more confrontation in our lives we are silent or passive and this also creates a spiral of emotions that are hard to deal with on top of our already heaping plates. This can lead to not taking part in actions, or going to events to avoid this, a lead and a symptom of de/oppression.

This is not a negatory or derisive observation it is simply a true one, and an important issue that must be addressed before we can go on much further as allies together. I recently had a talk a with a trusted ally who is also a friend and we both agree there is not enough learning and education about settlers and indigenous relations and how to effectively deal with it without the onus being on the indigenous to be the "teacher".

It is not our responsibility to take on all that we do in our daily lives, in our decolonization, and in our work with resistance, than also be expected by settlers and indigenous alike to take time

out to start from square one with every single settler we confront, or that confronts us and challenges us unfairly to "TEACH ME YOUR WAYS".

There is however a need to have some sort of resource guide or "schooling" in place to direct these people too. I attempted to roughly plot out a self help guide for settlers the infamous "Everyone wants to be an ally, until its time to some real ally shit". This was met with rave reviews, shit reviews, and a lot of traction. Yet every time I ask for feed back or ask settlers if they have done any of this or if it helped them the silence is deafening. To which reaffirms the need for a more in depth critical space and analysis to evolve a functioning model of teaching that is based in indigenous input and teachings, but implemented by settlers for settlers.

Ideally this should be done before the settler masses create more havoc than they already are in indigenous or POC movements. The need and desire to be included in what is right now a pretty trendy movement means we get a lot of extra work and if you really want to be an ally as a settler and a settler POC work needs to be done before hand to ensure the best outcome of whatever action is being undertaken.

We need to share, and lit each other up but there has to be boundaries, a lot of settlers and SPOC make themselves a pivotal person. Inserting yourself into others struggles is a faux pas at best described away by ignorance or learning process, at worst it is way to latch onto and appropriate a cause for whatever reason.

Some settlers or SPOC think that because they know a few radical indigenous or have been to a few actions, camps and took part in occupy or are anarchists they have a free pass to use those peoples names and causes to access and educate others on indigenous struggle or be an expert.

We have struggled so long not to be invisible and to have our issues brought out into the forefront and be acknowledged that we cannot allow anyone who is not us to be in a position of taking the wheel, it is our place and space to speak up and stand out even if we shy away from it!

What will our future generations think of us and our struggle if it seems we are always deferring and allowing settlers and SPOC

to hold the audience. It reinforces the notion and mythology that we need a saviour, that unless we are validated by a settler or SPOC our voices are not for speaking for ourselves but for agreeing with the settlers voice and world view on our issues.

Nothing could be more further from the reality and truth, that is where the line must be drawn. Regardless of how much information and first hand knowledge you have it of the situation at hand you can never present this in the way an indigenous person could.

Now I can already hear the false logic of but your people already know what you're saying and we are trying to raise awareness of this in a bigger audience (read make it palatable and without personal feelings) and educate our own people, this is why we need to speak at your events, or say the same thing you are saying but in a different way. We get it, white people and people of color listen better and can empathize more with their people, because after all we are the same way. It is presented in a way that speaks to you, and your experience. Great - do that on your own time and in your spaces.

Do not take the audience or the spotlight away from our limited amount of time, and our resources; taking up space in this way at indigenous events, actions, and spaces that are set up specifically so we can relay important messages, network, and raise support for OURSLEVES is disrespectful, create your own events and dialogues that are based on settler and SPOC world views on your own time.

When settlers and SPOC take the lead or insert themselves into the dialogue as a leader or person it gives them opportunity to either blatantly or unconsciously push their own agenda and present things in a biased way that makes it seem like what they want to see and what they hope to happen is the only or best course of action.

Imposing your wants and needs on Indigenous communities is oppressive and colonial, there is so much entitlement and privilege in trying to fast track actions or push situations that the people normally would take more time to debate on and this creates situations where the communities are let hanging in the wind while the "supporters" are already off on the new cause du jour leaving these endeavours to fail or lose momentum and this

looks bad in the grand scheme of things: "those ndns cant follow through on anything", "they are so disorganized", "what was the point if they didn't follow thru".

Yes we understand your sense of urgency we feel it too, but until we build a solid support system and strategically organize for the long term nothing much will come of these scattered defensive moves. Create space to share and vent with each other, to teach each other and to debrief yourselves during actions and after events. Create space in your being to allow yourself to be humble and to listen to the direction of the people, create space to exit spaces and conversations if you cannot be quiet and just learn, create space to learn how to not always be in on meetings and know when to refuse invitations.

The sad thing when these very incidents happen with settlers and SPOC is that they probably know on a level inside themselves they are not acknowledging openly because they are so gratified and validated to be seen as someone important, and because they have an indigenous person or two who allow this to happen for whatever reason.

However the onus is on the settlers and SPOC to withdraw from this attention-seeking saviour behaviour, and to call out their comrades when they see them acting this way. There is nothing wrong with firmly showing them how this is not helping but rather harming, there is nothing wrong with ensuring as a settler or SPOC that you are being actively supportive of the indigenous people without trying to own the issue or space or dominate it with your needs or need to be heard.

There is a time and a place for y'all and its pretty much all the time except when we the indigenous can eke out a small amount of space and time inside of the playground that is the protest industry of NGOs, ENGOs, Non Profits, and of course the many social and enviro movements, and our time is usually fraught with the here we go attitudes, the they always make it about them thoughts that are so deep we can waste our precious moments on our platform just struggling not to drown in the miasma of mingled guilt, embarrassment, and resentment for reminding everyone we are still HERE and are the ones with the most at stake.

Settlers and to a certain degree SPOC have privileges we do not,

ANCESTRAL PRIDE

there is never not a time when a settler isn't fully represented in the media or the mainstream society, there is never not a time you are not taken care of and your issues and spaces respected to the point they dominate and ultimately smother all other world views.

SPOC do have a tiny bit more privilege than we the indigenous do as it is the settler lens that sought to eradicate us from the earth and sight, so often we are forgotten by SPOC as well. I cannot count the conversations and things I have heard and witnessed where I or other indigenous had to just say HEY, aren't you forgetting whole nations in your intersectionality and praxis?

We need allies, we need solidarity, we need sharing on social networks and we need others to discuss and formulate plans of action along side of ours and to educate themselves.

What we don't need is settlers and SPOC creating friction and tension by trying to place themselves in places of power over the indigenous struggle and in places of being a spokesperson or somehow always without really "meaning" to be in the spotlight but somehow "oh my wow thank you so much you really shouldn't, I am so honoured but no it wasn't ALL me" being there anyways.

Not cool.

BY XOLPAKELXHIT, ANCESTRAL PRIDE

SETTLER SELF-CHECK

These are a series of questions that could be useful to ask yourself, if you are someone who identifies as a settler and are seeking to challenge your own thinking and actions… these questions come out of many conversations with many people and a great deal of work that Indigenous people have done to further the conversation of what it means to be in solidarity.

- Do you know whose lands you are living/organizing/working/protesting on? Do you have relationships with anyone from the Indigenous nation(s) in the area you are in? Why or why not? How could you change that?

- If you are part of an action that involves Indigenous people or communities, do you plan to stick around even after the confrontation/conflict/escalation has happened? How can you support long-term and what are people asking for?

- In a situation where police or other "authorities" are involved, are you acting in a way that might bring more heat and violence down on Indigenous people who may not have the desire/ability/resources to leave the situation? How can you support Indigenous land defenders and not heighten the risk?

- If you are collaborating with Indigenous people, are you checking your own assumptions about what people "should" be doing? Have you thought about all the factors that might be involved in decision-making?

- Coming to a space of front-line struggle to be "healed", who are you expecting to do that healing for you? How can you seek out supports in your life so that you aren't asking front-line Indigenous land defenders to "heal" you? How can you come together and create structures to support your own healing before you come into front-line spaces?

- Are you eager to "see some shit go down" or get a taste of struggle? Are you aware of the risks that people are facing and acting in accordance? What could happen after you leave? Are you escalating risk or contributing to powerful resistance responsibly?

- If there is an action/protest/event/camp/etc. happening, are you so busy getting ready to head up there that you haven't heard or thought through what is being asked for? Sometimes there are very specific asks that get ignored because they are not as "exciting" or "sexy" as getting to be in the spotlight. Do you have relationships with people you could check in with about what might be most useful?

- What would long-term solidarity look like? How would people that you are organizing with feel supported best and what role can you play? It can be hard to disconnect from an ego-place of trying to "look" like you are a really good ally, but letting go of the need to be "seen" as anything can lead to more intentional, less superficial solidarity. What does that look like for the people you are working with?

- "Travel privilege" means having the privilege/resources/access to go to places (protests/actions/camps/conferences, etc.) that many front-line folks may not be able to travel to. In situations where there is a call for people to come, are there ways that you can share your resources instead with Indigenous folks who would like to go or that you could re-think how you engage, to support more front-line Indigenous people being able to take part?

- Are you taking credit for Indigenous peoples' words/work/resistance? How can you center Indigenous voices and resistance, rather than settlers'?
Where does your knowledge come from?

- When entering into relationships with Indigenous people and communities as a group of non-Indigenous supporters/organizers/would-be allies, have you worked on your own issues within your groups, so as not to bring those dynamics into your relationship of solidarity? For example, if patriarchy, transphobia or racism is an issue within the group, are you actively finding ways to challenge it and strengthen the group's collective well-being?

- How do you take feedback? Are you able to hear what someone is saying and then think through how you have impacted the person offering feedback? Are you able to appreciate the difficulty involved in giving feedback, especially given the tendency of settlers towards defensiveness, denial and even violence?

- If you are actively working with or organizing with Indigenous people and communities, do you listen to and have relationships with Indigenous women, Two-Spirit people and youth? Are you only working with the more visible or "official" voices within a community? How can you connect with people who may have a different experience/viewpoint/opinion?

- What are the skills that you have? What are you bringing to the front-lines and what are people asking for? How can you "skill up"?

- What are the privileges you have? How can you use those strategically? Are you wasting your privileges by denying them?

- Are you grounded in place when it comes to organizing with people or do you find yourself in different places constantly? How does this affect your ability to be an effective, long-term supporter? What would it look like to stay in one place and build community and a culture of resistance with a community, if that is what the community is asking for?

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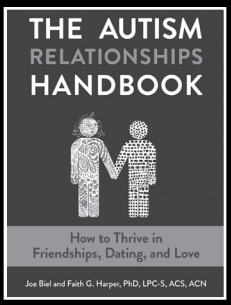

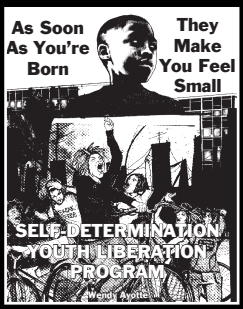

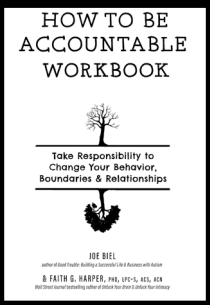

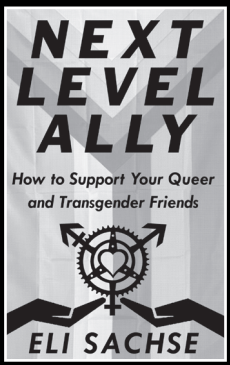

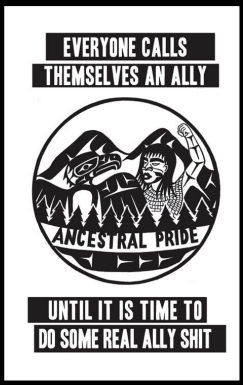

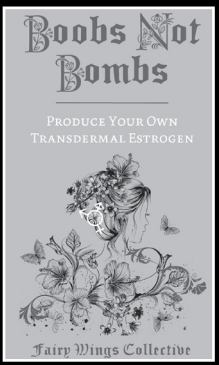

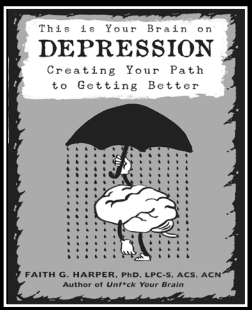

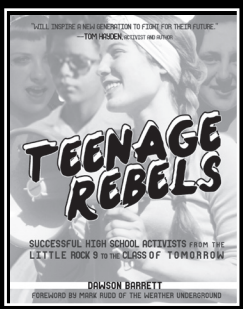

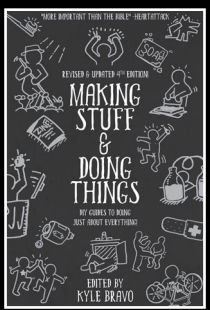

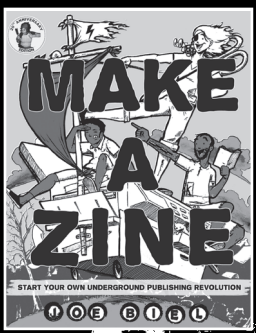

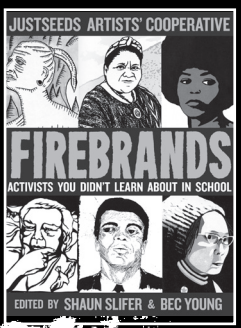

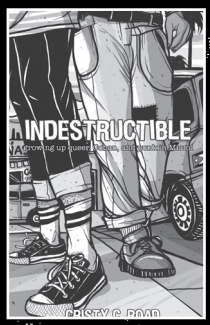

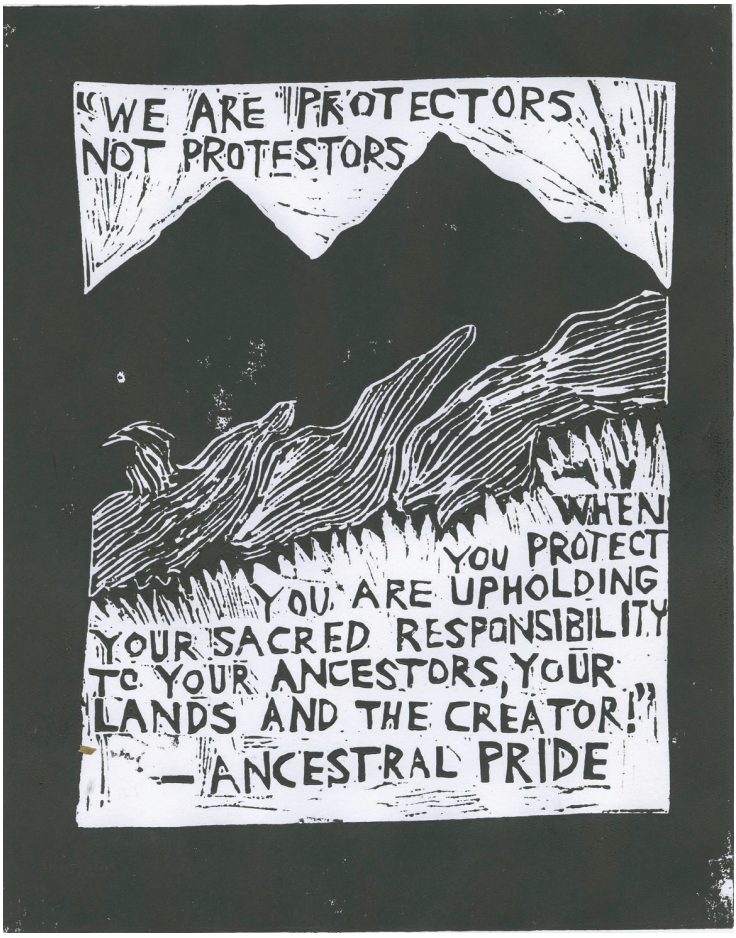

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